

POU11011: Introduction to Political Science

Lecture 1 (Teaching Week 2): Is this politics?

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Is *this* politics?

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Case 1: the rent freeze

A government caps how much a landlord can raise the rent. A landlord says it's confiscation and stops maintaining the property. A tenant says it's the only thing standing between her and homelessness. Neither of them is lying.



Case 2: the family row

Sunday dinner at home. Someone brings up the Occupied Territories Bill: should Ireland ban trade with illegal settlements? One cousin thinks it's basic decency. Another thinks it's virtue-signalling that will cost jobs. Nobody's vote is being counted. Nobody's a politician. Voices are raised anyway.



Case 3: the nurses' strike

Nurses walk out. Patients' appointments get cancelled. The union says pay hasn't kept pace with the cost of living. The HSE says there's no more money to give. Someone, eventually, has to decide who bends.



Case 4: the viral post

Someone posts something. It gets four million views by lunchtime. A politician is forced to respond. A policy that wasn't on anyone's radar yesterday is on the evening news tonight.

Case 5: the coup

Soldiers surround a parliament building. The president is placed under house arrest. State television starts playing military marches. By morning there's a new government and nobody voted for it.



Which of these is politics?

1. The rent freeze
2. The family row
3. The nurses' strike
4. The viral post
5. The coup

What do all five have in common?

- Somebody wants something somebody else doesn't want to give.
- There isn't enough of it to go around: money, respect, land, power, the right to be listened to.
- Eventually, *some* outcome happens. A decision gets made, even if that decision is “nothing changes.”

That's the core of politics: **conflict, plus collective decision-making, under scarcity.**

A working definition

Politics: *the process by which people decide, collectively, how to handle the things they disagree about: who gets what, who's bound by the outcome, and whether that outcome sticks.*

Notice what's *not* in that definition: parliaments, elections, politicians. Those are one place politics happens. They are not the only place.

Four ways people have defined it

Political scientists have argued about this for a while. Roughly:

- **The art of government** — what happens in cabinet rooms and parliaments. (Narrow.)
- **Public affairs** — anything in the public sphere, stops at the front door.
- **Compromise and consensus** — *a method*: settling disagreement by negotiation rather than force. (Crick's view, next slide.)
- **Power** — anywhere one person or group gets another to do something they wouldn't otherwise do. (Broadest.)

Why bother defining it at all?

Because how you draw the line decides what counts as a *political* problem and what gets waved away as “just personal,” “just private,” “just the market.”

Bernard Crick's defence

“Politics [is] the activity by which differing interests within a given unit of rule are conciliated by giving them a share of power in proportion to their importance to the welfare and the survival of the whole community.”

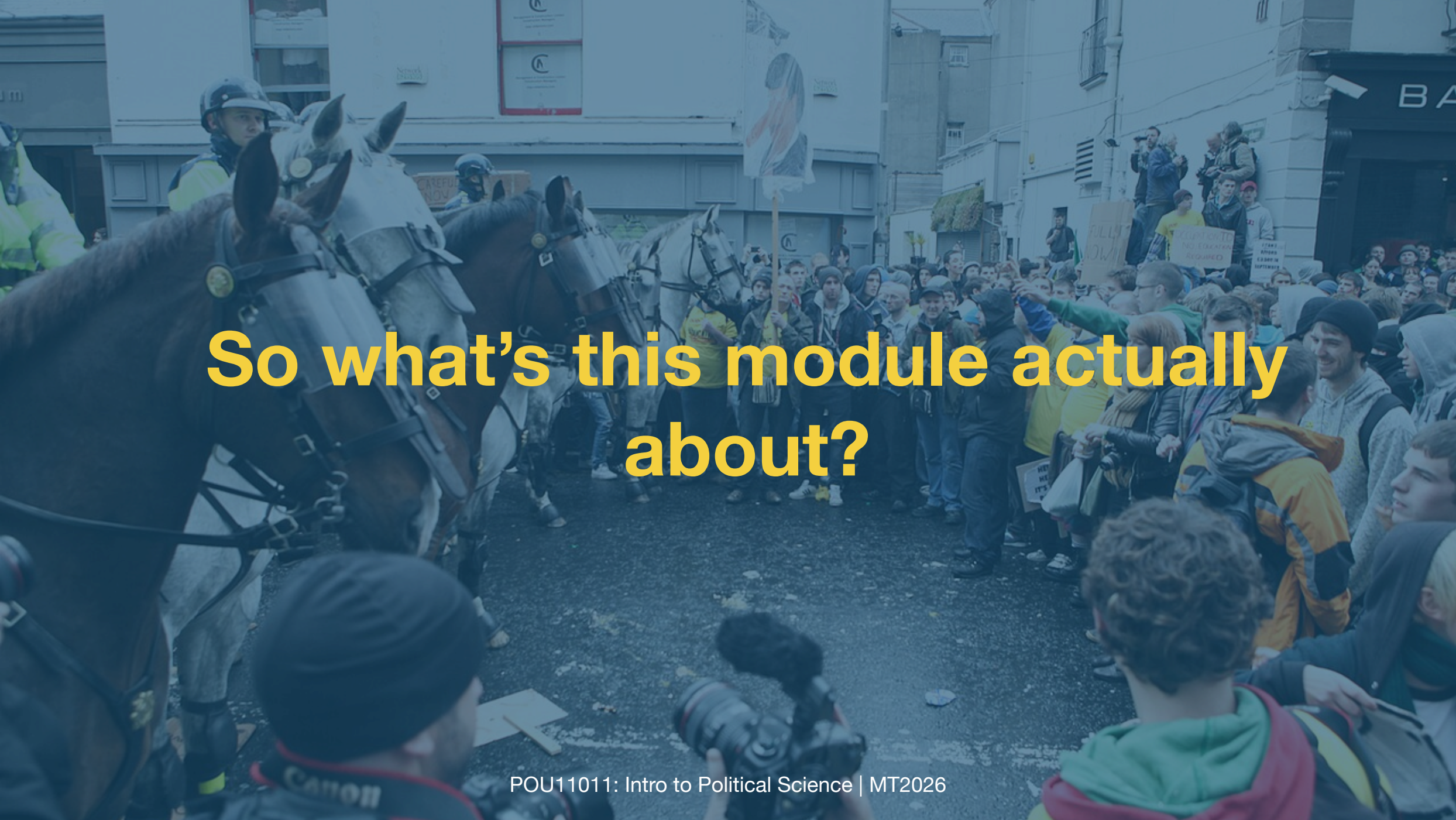
— Bernard Crick, In Defence of Politics (1962)

Crick's real point isn't the definition. It's the *defence*: politics, messy, slow, compromising, beats the alternatives.

The kicker

- Politics is not the noise that gets in the way of solving problems!
- Politics **is** how societies solve problems they can't solve by force or by unanimous agreement...which is most problems.
- Every case today was politics working (or straining, or breaking). None of them were an aberration.

That's the argument this module is built on. Everything from here is “so, how does that actually work?”



So what's this module actually about?

Three questions before reading week

1. **Where do states come from and why can some of them actually run a country while others can't?**
2. **What are people on the left and the right actually arguing about?**
3. **Why do a few identities become battle lines, and most never do?**

And three after it

4. **Democracy or dictatorship and would you notice the moment one turned into the other?**
5. **Who can stop whom?** Constitutions, parliaments, planning objectors: who actually holds a veto?
6. **How do we know any of this is true** and how do political scientists get fooled?

Politics vs political *science*

- **Systematic comparison**
- **Evidence rather than anecdote**
- **“How do we really you know that?”**

Who am I?

- From Minneapolis, Minnesota.
- Lived in New York, Abu Dhabi, and Moscow before Dublin.
- My own research: Russian politics, authoritarianism, corruption. When and why mayors get arrested, why some autocracies are more corrupt than others, how ordinary people decide whether to protest.

How this module works

- Two 50-minute lectures a week, ten teaching weeks (twenty slots total). This is one of them.
- Four tutorials across the term, led by TAs, not weekly, and not mini-lectures. They're where you argue about the cases.
- Readings: Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, 6th edition (2025).

How you'll be assessed

- **10% — tutorial discussion points.** A short written submission before each of the four tutorials, plus attendance at all four.
- **30% — a short assignment.** An 800-word blog post applying a course concept to a live political event.
- **60% — a final essay.** 1,500 words, end of term, your choice from a set of questions.

Next up

Read: Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, Chapter 1, the sections on power and the “faces of power.”

Think about this: who has power over your daily life that you have *never once watched them exercise*?

See you Friday

See you Friday

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Slides and readings: noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou11011-mt2026

Reading for next time is on the module page and Blackboard.